

span of the bridge. Repeat raids ensured the North Vietnamese were unable to repair the damage during the war—but they were ingenious at finding alternatives.

The smart bombs were a highly effective addition to the US armory, but their use required good weather. This was a disadvantage that remained problematic throughout the bombing campaign. As of August 12, some 22,400 sorties had been scheduled but 15 percent were abandoned due to bad weather. Henry Kissinger expressed rage at the shortfall. Although barely half the listed targets had been hit, the operation was unquestionably more successful than the raids that preceded it.

“We know very little about the situation in the north.”

PHILIP A. ODEEN (NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL STAFF) TO HENRY KISSINGER, AUGUST 12, 1972